

Old Father Time Becomes a Terror

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1 Once upon a time, technology, we thought, would make our lives easier. Machines were expected to do our work for us, leaving us with ever-increasing quantities of time to **waste awayⁱ** on **idlenessⁱⁱ** and pleasure.

i. Waste away is a phrasal verb, 动词短语; it means to become weaker. The sentence can be paraphrased in this way: Machines were expected to do our work, creating an increasing amount of time for us to become weaker in laziness and joy.

ii. idle means lazy. Idleness = laziness, 无所事事;

2 But instead of **liberating(解放)** us, technology has **enslavedⁱⁱⁱ** us. Innovations are occurring at a **bewildering(=confusing)** rate: as many now arrive in a year as^{iv} once arrived in a millennium. And as each invention arrives, it **eats** further **into** our time.

iii. Enslave = en+slave. *En-* means cause to be, make into. E.g. Endear means to make sth into something dear; enslave means to cause sb to be a slave; enable means to make sb or sth able to do.

iv. As 在英语中的使用非常灵活。它既可以是介词，副词，还可以是连词。

首先，在 I am as old as you 中，第一个 as 为副词，表示同等地，equally, to the same degree of; 第二个 as 为介词，表示 like, 像。而当我们后面半句的谓语写出来，I am as old as you are. 这时，后一个 as 又是连词，连接一个句子——I am as old as you are (old).

在不同的词典里，对于 as...as 前后词性的解释并不唯一。但无论哪种解释，我们的查阅目的都是一致的，那就是能够让自己理解，并尝试使用即可。

3 The motorcar, for example, promised unimaginable levels of personal **mobility**. But now, traffic in cities moves more slowly than it did in the days of the **horse-drawn carriage(马车)**, and we waste our lives **stuck^v** in traffic jams.

v. Be/get stuck in 表示在某事上被困住，例如：I got stuck in French. 我搞不懂法语。

注意：Get stuck 是非正式用语，不用于学术写作之中。

4 The aircraft promised new horizons, too. The trouble is, it **delivered** them. Its very existence created a demand for **time-consuming** journeys that we would never **previously** have dreamed of **undertaking^{vi}** -- the **transatlantic^{vii}** shopping expedition, for example, or the trip to a **convention(=conference, meeting)** on the other side of the world.

vi. Undertake 是个高级词，同学们一定要有意识使用。Undertake means 1) to put oneself under obligation to perform(承担某事); 2) set about doing something, begin to do(着手开始做). An undertaking = a task. E.g. 写作策略是本学期读写课的重点任务：The undertaking of this semester's English course is the general academic writing strategies.

vii. Trans- means across. Apart from transatlantic, we have transcultural, trans-continental.

5 In most cases, technology has not saved time, but enabled us to do more things. In the home, washing machines promised to **free** women from having to **toil(= to work hard or to do with laborious effort 卖力地做)** over the laundry. In reality, they encouraged us to change

our clothes daily instead of weekly, creating seven times as much washing and **ironing**(熨烫). Similarly, the weekly **bath** has been replaced by the daily **shower**, **multiplying** the hours spent on personal **grooming**(梳妆打扮).

6 Meanwhile, technology has not only allowed work to spread into our leisure time -- the laptop-on-the-beach **syndrome** -- but added the new **burden** of dealing with faxes, e-mails and voicemails. It has also provided us with the opportunity to spend hours fixing software glitches on our personal computers or filling our heads with useless information from the Internet.

7 Technology apart, the Internet points the way to a second reason why we feel so **time-pressed**: the information **explosion**(v. explode).

8 **A couple of**(= a few) centuries ago, nearly all the world's **accumulated** learning could be **contained**(=preserve, hold) in the heads of a few philosophers. Today, those heads could not hope to **accommodate**(=contain, hold) more than a tiny **fraction**^{vii} of the information **generated**(=created) in a single day.

viii. 这里做一个词形辨析:

Fraction means portion, part;

Faction means a party, 党派;

Fiction, 小说;

Fracture: break, tear, 折断, 打断, 骨折;

Friction: 摩擦力

9 News, facts and opinions pour in from every corner of the world. The television set offers 150 **channels**. There are millions of Internet sites. Magazines, books and CD-ROMs **proliferate**^{ix}.

ix. Proliferate means to multiply, accumulate, increase, grow.

10 "In the whole world of **scholarship**^x, there were only **a handful of**(=a few) scientific journals in the 18th century, and the publication of a book was an event^{xi}," says Edward Wilson, honorary curator in entomology at Harvard University's museum of **comparative** zoology. "Now, I find myself **subscribing to**(订阅) 60 or 70 journals or magazines just to keep me up with what **amounts to**^{xii} a minute **proportion**^{xiii} of the **expanding frontiers**(学术前沿) of scholarship."

x. 本科阶段要求同学们记忆 scholarship 两层含义: 1) a grant to a student 奖学金; 2) a fund of knowledge and learning, 知识库, 学术. E.g. Learn to use the scholarship of the ancients. 学会借鉴前人的智慧。

xi. The publication of a book was an event means it was a great happening. 过去, 出版书籍不可小觑。

xii. Amount to here simply means to be equal as, to be the same with. 等同于, 是一个动词短语。

xiii. Proportion means fraction.

11 There is another reason for our increased time stress levels, too: rising **prosperity**. As ever-larger quantities of goods and services are produced, they have to be **consumed**. Driven on by advertising, we do our best to **oblige**^{xiv}: we buy more, travel more and play more, but

we struggle to keep up. So we suffer from what Wilson calls **discontent** with super **abundance**^{xv} -- the **confusion** of endless choice.

xiv. Oblige means to do something as a favour, 好心帮忙, 效力。The text simply means that "We follow what the ads advise us to do."

xv. 再来做一个词形辨析:

Abundant, abundance means full of variety, plenty, ample 富足, 充裕, 丰富, 大量;

Abandon means to give up, yield. 表示摒弃; abandoned, adj. 被遗弃的。

12 Of course, not everyone is **overstressed**. "It's a convenient **shorthand**^{xvi} to say we're all time-starved, but we have to remember that it only applies to, say, half the population," says Michael Willmott, director of the Future Foundation, a London research company.

xvi. Shorthand means a method of writing by substituting characters, letters, sounds, words. 表示为了速记而创造的一些符号。这种符号的特征是简单通俗。So in our text, "It's a convenient shorthand to say" means it's so simple, so easy to say that everyone is busy.

13 "You've got people retiring early, you've got the unemployed, you've got other people maybe only **peripherally**^{xvii} **involved** in the economy who don't have this situation at all."^{xviii} If you're unemployed, your problem is that you've got too much time, not too little."

xvii. "You've got something" is a very, very, very **informal** expression. **DO NOT** use it in your writing. 在学术写作之中, 同学们务必避免使用 you've got..., 这是非常非常不正式的表达。You've got 表示你有, 其实就是 there is, there are: There are people retiring early, there are the unemployed, there are other people maybe only slightly involved in the economy...

xviii. 除了 margin, edge, frame, outline, border, boundary 等等, 这里又学到与边缘、边界含义相近的词汇, 叫做 peripherally, 副词, 表示边缘化地, 即少部分地;

14 Paul Edwards, **chairman**(=head, leader, president) of the London-based Henley Centre forecasting group, points out that the feeling of pressures can also be **exaggerated**, or **self-imposed**^{xix}. "Everyone talks about it so much that about 50 percent of unemployed or retired people will tell you they never have enough time to get things done," he says. "It's almost got to the point where there's stress **envy**. If you're not stressed, you're not succeeding. Everyone wants to have a little bit of this stress to show they're an important person."

xix. Impose means force sth unwelcome to be accepted, 表示将某种(不受欢迎)的事物强加给某物或某人。原文: "...the feeling of pressures can be self-imposed" means that such unpleasant feeling can be imposed on people by themselves. 这种紧迫感有时会是人们自己强压给自己的。Impose 这个词在 quiz 3 里肯定要考, 是个六级词汇。

15 There is another aspect to all of this too. Hour-by-hour logs kept by thousands of volunteers over the decades have shown that, in the U.K., working hours have risen only **slightly** in the last 10 years, and in the U.S., they have actually fallen -- even for those in professional and executive jobs, where the **perceptions**(感知, = sense) of stress are highest.

16 In the U.S., John Robinson, professor of sociology at the University of Maryland, and Geoffrey Godbey, professor of leisure studies at Penn State University found that, since the mid-1960s, **the average American**^{xx} **had gained**^{xxi} five hours a week in free time -- that is, time

left after working, sleeping, commuting, caring for children and doing the chores.

xx. The average American means a common American, 一个普通的美国人;

xxi. 这里为什么能用 had done? 英语的陈述句里(非虚拟), 永远永远只有一种可能用过去完成时, **那就是有发生在过去的非常明确的时间界定**, 例如: 在秦王朝, 在 17 世纪科学革命之时等等。所以, 原文的这句话作者用了 had done, 这就说明作者一定是给出了明确的起始时间和结束时间。它的起始时间非常简单, 是 since the mid-1960s, 截止时间在哪儿? 截止时间是到 John Robinson 和 Geoffrey Godbey 这两人的研究之时。我们来画个图:



老师标粗的地方是使用 had done 的位置。也就是说, 从 16 世纪中期一直到这两位研究者做研究之前, 美国人休息时长增长了。在往后写作之中, **在大家没有绝对把握的情况下, 少用 had done**, 否则语法扣分是严重的。

17 The gains, however, were **unevenly distributed**. The people who **benefited** the most were singles and empty-nesters. Those who gained the least -- less than an hour -- were working couples with pre-school children, perhaps reflecting the trend for parents to spend more time **nurturing**^{xxii} their **offspring**.

xxii. Nurture means to educate, to further develop. We often compare these two terms: nature vs nurture. 先天遗传 vs 后天养成;

18 There is, of course, a gender issue here, too. Advances in household **appliances (machines, equipment, instruments)** may have encouraged women to take paying jobs: but as we have already noted, technology did not end household chores. As a result, we see **appalling**^{xxiii} inequalities in the distribution of free time between the sexes. According to the Henley Centre, working fathers in the U. K. average 48 hours of free time a week. Working mothers get 14.

xxiii. Appalling = shocking, surprising, startling, astonishing, staggering, 这全是我们学过的。

19 Inequalities apart, the perception of the time famine is widespread, and has **provoked**^{xxiv} a variety of reactions. One is an attempt to gain the largest possible amount of satisfaction from the smallest possible investment of time. People today want fast food, sound bytes and **instant gratification**^{xxv}. And they become **upset(=anxious, ill at ease, uneasy, worried)** when time is wasted.

xxiv. Provoke means to stir, trigger 激起, 煽动;

xxv. This is the explanation of "instant gratification": the temptation, and resulting tendency, to forego a future benefit in order to obtain a less rewarding but more immediate benefit. 为了最快获利, 而不考虑长久而更大利益的行为倾向。和它相反的是 delayed gratification, 即, 为了能获得更长久的利益而延迟满足。

20 "People talk about quality time(品质时间). They want perfect moments," says the Henley Centre's Edwards. "If you take your kids to a movie and McDonald's and it's not perfect, you've wasted an afternoon, and it's a sense that you've lost something **precious**. If you lose some money you can earn some more, but if you waste time you can never get it back."

21 People are also trying to buy time. Anything that helps **streamline^{xxvi}** our lives is a growth market. One example is what Americans call concierge services -- **domestic** help, childcare, gardening and decorating. And on-line retailers are seeing big increases in sales -- though not, **as yet**(=yet), profits.

xxvi. Streamline in our text means to make simpler or more efficient. 使某物变得更加简单和高效。

22 A third reaction to time **famine**(饥荒) has been the growth of the work-life debate. You hear more about people taking early retirement or giving up high pressure jobs in favour of occupations with shorter working hours. And bodies such as Britain's National Work-Life Forum have **sprung up**(to appear suddenly), **urging** employers to end the long-hours culture among managers and to adopt family-friendly working policies.

23 The trouble with all these reactions is that liberating time -- whether by making better use of it, buying it from others or reducing the amount spent at work -- is **futile**(=ineffective, 无用的) if the hours gained are immediately **diverted**(=turn, 转移到) to other purposes.

24 As Godbey points out, the stress we feel **arises^{xxvii}** not from a **shortage** of time, but from the **surfeit**(=excess, overabundance 过满) of things we try to **cram^{xxviii}** into it. "It's the kid in the candy store," he says. "There's just so many good things to do. **The array of^{xxix}** choices is stunning. Our free time is increasing, but not as fast as our sense of the necessary."

xxvii. Arise here means to originate from a source, to come from, 来源于, 来自于;

xxviii. Cram means to fill, to stuff, 塞, 灌, 挤.

xxix. An array of means a variety of, a great number of.

25 A more successful **remedy**(=solution) may lie in understanding the problem rather than **evading**(=avoid) it.

26 Before the industrial revolution, people lived in small communities with limited communications. Within the **confines^{xxx}** of their village, they could reasonably expect to know everything that was to be known, see everything that was to be seen, and do everything that was to be done.

xxx. Confine means to limit, restrict. It is also a noun. As a noun, it means a border, a wall, or something that encloses or restricts. 表示围栏, 边界。

27 Today, being curious by nature, we are still trying to do the same. But the global village is a world of limitless possibilities, and we can never achieve our aim.

28 It is not more time we need: it is fewer desires. We need to switch off the cell-phone and leave the children to play by themselves. We need to buy less, read less and travel less. We need to set boundaries for ourselves, or be **doomed** to **mounting^{xxxi}** despair.

xxxi. Be doomed to means to destine, make certain the failure of 注定要. He was doomed to a life of loneliness. Mount means to increase, so mounting despair means an increasing or growing despair. 即逐渐上升的绝望, 是个形容词, 表示不断累积的, accumulating, growing.